

IMPORTED ARSENAL

INDIA CONTINUES TO REMAIN THE WORLD'S SECOND-LARGEST DEFENCE IMPORTER. THE DEPENDENCE IS WORRYINGLY HIGH FOR SOME CRITICAL EQUIPMENT

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Propulsion is the single most important technology that India cannot produce at scale

A**T AERO INDIA** last year, the Ministry of Defence announced that 65-70% of India's defence needs were now met indigenously. This was a complete reversal from a decade ago, when this was the import percentage. Defence production reached a record high of ₹1.27 lakh crore (\$15.4 billion) in FY24. This was a 174% increase from FY15. Exports crossed ₹23,622 crore (\$2.77 billion) in 2025 with Indian artillery, radars, counter-drone systems, and BrahMos cruise missile finding buyers from the Philippines to Armenia.

However, India continued to remain the world's second-largest defence importer, preceded by Ukraine, which has been facing a protracted war. The Stockholm International Peace Research Institute (SIPRI) has ranked India as the world's second-largest importer of arms and military hardware from 2021 to 2025.

The trend will continue. For 2026-2031, India has planned several high-value foreign purchases, despite the push for indigenisation. Some of the big-ticket ones are 114 Rafale fighter jets for the Indian Air Force (IAF) from France, 26 Rafale M for the Indian Navy, again

from France, MQ 9B drones from the US, P-8I reconnaissance and maritime surveillance aircraft from the US, additional S 400 air defence systems from Russia, jet engines from France, and advanced missile systems from Israel.

The Indian Army is the least import-intensive but needs foreign armoured propulsion and precision munitions. The 15-year plan calls for 1,800 futuristic tanks, 50,000+ next-generation ATGMs (Anti-Tank Guided Missiles), and 400 UAV-launched precision guided missiles, many of which will need foreign inputs. Javelin anti-armor systems (\$46 million) and Ex-